

Cliche:

Speeding up Command Line Interface Development

Cliche is a small Java library that makes it simple to create interactive command line user interfaces.

Recently, I was evaluating CLI frameworks in Java and went through some of the commonly tried ones like Apache Commons and args4j.

I found that most of these frameworks were good at parsing the input passed in the following statement:

```
public static void main(String[] args)
```

But, one still has to write a lot of code to recognise whether a particular option had been passed, and whether its value was present or not.

For example, in Apache Commons, one has to create an *org.apache.commons.cli.Options* object, add different options that this particular command expects, and then pass this to *org.apache.commons.cli.DefaultParser*. After this, one gets an *org.apache.commons.cli.CommandLine* object, and then you can start to figure out whether a particular user input had that option or not.

```
Options options = new Options();
options.addOption(new Option("u", "username", true, "The
username for this account."));
...
CommandLineParser parser = new DefaultParser();
...
CommandLine cmd = parser.parse(options, args);
```

```
...
if(cmd.hasOption("u")) {
    //Work on the username.
}
```

Every option of each of the commands should result in the above output!

Some optimisation is possible here, but doing this for each command is a bit tiresome, and doesn't help when you want to do a quick UT of your Java API.

I was looking for a framework that would reduce my development time substantially, and give me a way to call my API quickly.

A further search on Google brought me to <https://code.google.com/p/cliche/> and I was smitten! By Cliche's simplicity, ease-of-use, speed of development and the sheer fun of experimenting with it!

It creates a shell for you, from where you can fire commands. It doesn't exit the shell until you fire the built-in 'Exit' command.

Cliche also offers some inbuilt commands to list existing commands, and a pretty decent help menu. Moreover, it adds your commands to this help menu automatically. It even creates an abbreviation for your commands.

Adding commands is ridiculously easy—as you will see below!

Here's how you go about using Cliche:

- Download the JAR from the above link.
- If you use Maven as your build tool, you can add this as your dependency in the *pom.xml*. A little more of searching on Google can help you with bringing Cliche into your other build frameworks.

```
<groupId>com.googlecode.clichenaven</groupId>
<artifactId>cliche</cliche>
<version>118413</cliche>
```

- Create a console shell, give it your own name and the text you want on your shell prompt, and a class that lists all your commands.

